

any medical education, including nursing and midwifery. Mani believes the film would be next to impossible to make today, simply because women have lost all "social and political rights". "Imagine a country with 20 million women with no access to health services," she says.

The UN calls this gender apartheid and Mani wants the world to know that is not what Afghanistan is all about. "Afghanistan is so much more than what people know it for today–Taliban, opium and war. We have a rich history of music, dance, literature and poetry. In the last 20 years, we had so many bright minds who had studied all over the world and had come back to rebuild the country. We stayed all this time even as the Taliban bombed schools, public spaces and even weddings and hospitals. We stayed because we love our home and wanted to rebuild it," she says.

TO MAKE *BREAD & ROSES*, MANI HAD TO RELY ON HER PROTAGONISTS FOR FOOTAGE

Mani was in Europe for a film festival when the Taliban regime came back to power and she hasn't been able to return since. This meant that, to make *Bread & Roses*, she had to completely rely on her protagonists to send her the footage she needed. "They had never done something like this before, so I had to teach them how to film themselves. I explained to them that I was interested in the details of their lives. So, if they were filming a meal, I'd want to feel like I'm right there with them. Often I would also film myself doing things and send those to them so that they understood."

Having Lawrence on the film's credits has helped it reach a larger audience. "The biggest problem I've faced as a documentary filmmaker from Afghanistan is that people think 'we've seen everything on the news, what more could there be'. Also Jennifer's involvement wasn't limited to putting her name. When we were editing in Sweden, she spent time with us talking about how the film is shaping up and saw the first cut." Nobel Peace Prize winner and activist Malala Yousafzai saw this first cut and came on board as an executive producer immediately. "When we talk about the Taliban and women's freedom and education, you can't not have Malala onboard. I am so grateful that both these women choose to use their platform to shine a light on what is a very urgent situation," adds Mani. ■

–Karishma Upadhyay



MAKING THE CUT »
(From far left clockwise) Scenes from Thangalaan, Bokshi, Bad Girl *and* The Slow Man and His Raft

Bengali-language *The Puppet's Tale*, based on the 1936 novel *Putulnacher Itikotha*.

The non-competitive Harbour section, home to the best contemporary cinema, is hosting six Indian films, some of them premieres. This includes *Bokshi*, Bhargav Saikia's horror film shot in the jungles of Sikkim; *Gaami*, Vidyadhar Kagita's Telugu punch-up of science fiction and fantasy; *Morichika*, Ishaan Ghose's film about a single mother and a Bihari migrant man in Kolkata; *Rhythm of a Flower*, Amit Dutta's animated feature-length look at the life of classical singer Kumar Gandharva; *The Slow Man and His Raft*, Pradipta Bhattacharyya's magic-realist tale set in rural Bengal; and *Theatre*, Nishanth Kalidindi's docufiction which tracks a cattle farmer travelling to the city to join a theatre troupe.

IFFR 2025 also includes documentaries such as Vani Subramaniam's *Cinema Pe Cinema* and Jagannathan Krishnan's *Videokaaran* (2009). ■

–Devarsi Ghosh